

UniNotes

PSYCHOLOGY

Cognitive Psychology Revision Guide

Memory, attention and research evaluation in concise, connected sections.

How to use these notes

Start with the key definitions, then use the tables/diagrams to connect ideas. Finish with the exam checklist. The aim is high information density: short wording, clear concepts, no filler.

1. Memory as information processing



The multi-store view separates sensory register, short-term memory (STM) and long-term memory (LTM). Attention transfers selected information into STM; rehearsal/encoding supports transfer to LTM; retrieval brings stored information back into active processing.

2. Working memory

Central executive	Directs attention and coordinates other systems.
Phonological loop	Temporarily stores/rehearses verbal and auditory information.
Visuo-spatial sketchpad	Temporarily handles visual and spatial information.
Episodic buffer	Integrates information across systems and with LTM.

3. Attention

Selective attention prioritises some inputs while filtering others. Divided attention becomes harder when tasks compete for the same limited cognitive resources. Automatic processing uses fewer conscious resources than controlled processing.

4. Encoding and retrieval

Deeper, semantic processing usually improves long-term retention more than shallow processing. Retrieval is affected by cues: context-dependent and state-dependent effects occur when information available at learning is reinstated at recall.

Applied revision

Use retrieval practice rather than repeated rereading: close the notes, answer a question from memory, then check and correct.

5. Evaluating evidence

Reliability	Consistency/repeatability of a measure.
Validity	Whether a study/measure captures what it claims.
Ecological validity	How well findings generalise to real-world settings.
Confound	Uncontrolled factor that changes with the independent variable.
Correlation	Association; does not by itself prove causation.

Exam-ready checklist

- Contrast multi-store memory with working memory.
- Know the four working-memory components.
- Explain selective vs divided attention.
- Explain how encoding depth and retrieval cues affect memory.
- Use reliability, validity, confounds and causation accurately when evaluating studies.

Fast recall

If you cannot explain a concept in one or two sentences without looking, revisit that section. Aim to recall the definition, mechanism and one example.

Uni Notes keeps revision focused: concise explanations, useful detail, and diagrams only where they improve understanding.